



RAMAN SINGH
(CENTRE)
HAS MADE
DEVELOPMENT
THE FOCUS OF
HIS CAMPAIGN

An Officer and the GENTLEMAN

Local issues and personality clashes dominate the polls as Ajit Jogi makes a concerted attempt to dislodge the popular Raman Singh

| By Ambreesh Mishra |

He may not be a blue blood but he's a proud Rajput, and the chief minister of a state where even the erstwhile royalty is mostly tribal. In Chhattisgarh, where numbers go against the upper castes, Raman Singh is perhaps the ruling BJP's biggest asset in the forthcoming assembly elections. The party's strategy has always been to project a chief ministerial face and this seems to be working. With wife Veena Singh taking care of his Rajnandgaon

constituency, the chief minister is on a whirlwind tour in his helicopter. With his hugely popular Rs 3 per kg cheap rice scheme—the first subsidised foodgrain programme in any north Indian state—he has earned a new sobriquet. Chants of '*Chaur wale baba*' (the elder who provides rice) go up as he touches base with picture-perfect but Naxal-affected tribal belt in Bastar, where the cheap rice has touched a chord.

Taking him on is Ajit Jogi, an ex-IAS officer-turned-Congressman.

He was also the first chief minister of the state and was dislodged by Raman Singh in 2003. Now, it seems that Jogi wants his old job back. He is in the fray from Marwahi (ST) seat and has walked away with the largest chunk of tickets for his supporters, some Congress leaders putting the figure at almost half of the 90 seats in the state. The party has left three seats for Sharad Pawar's NCP. As for the rest, the Congress has repeated most of its sitting MLAs (most are Jogi loyalists), fielding only three new faces. The

The ticket demographics

WOMEN
Congress—10
BJP—10

SCs
Congress—10
BJP—10

BRAHMINS
Congress—07
BJP—05

RAJPUTS
Congress—05
BJP—03

BANIYAS
Congress—07
BJP—08

OBCs
Congress—27
BJP—35